

NCLEX DERMATITIS & CELLULITIS OVERVIEW

1. WHAT IS DERMATITIS?

- **Dermatitis = Inflammation (swelling, redness) of the skin** caused by irritants, allergens, or underlying conditions.
- It is **NOT contagious** (doesn't spread from person to person).

2. TYPES OF DERMATITIS & THEIR CAUSES

Type of Dermatitis	Cause (What Triggers It?)	Symptoms (What It Looks Like?)
Atopic Dermatitis (Eczema)	Genetic, allergies, asthma (often runs in families)	Itchy, dry, red, scaly patches (often on face, hands, elbows, knees)
Contact Dermatitis	Touching an irritant/allergen (soaps, chemicals, poison ivy)	Red rash, itching, burning, blisters (if severe)
Seborrheic Dermatitis ("Dandruff")	Overgrowth of yeast on skin (oily skin, stress, genetics)	Greasy, yellowish, scaly patches on scalp, face, chest
Stasis Dermatitis	Poor blood flow (usually in legs)	Swollen, discolored skin with open sores (often on lower legs)

3. DERMATITIS TREATMENT

- ✓ **Avoid Triggers:** Stop using irritating soaps, chemicals, or allergens.
- ✓ **Moisturize Daily:** Prevents dry skin (use fragrance-free lotions).
- ✓ **Topical Steroids (Hydrocortisone, Betamethasone):** Reduces redness & itching.
- ✓ **Antihistamines (Diphenhydramine/Benadryl):** Helps with itching.

✓ **For Seborrheic Dermatitis:** Use **antifungal shampoos** (Ketoconazole, Selenium Sulfide).

✓ **For Stasis Dermatitis:** Elevate legs, wear compression stockings (to improve circulation).

4. WHAT IS CELLULITIS?

- **Cellulitis = A bacterial skin infection that spreads in deeper layers of the skin.**
- **Common bacteria:**
 - **Streptococcus (Strep) or Staphylococcus (Staph)** bacteria enter through **a cut, wound, or insect bite.**
- **Cellulitis is NOT contagious**, but it can spread **inside the body** and cause **serious infections (sepsis or bone infection)** if untreated.

5. SYMPTOMS OF CELLULITIS

- ♦ **Red, swollen, warm skin** (often on legs but can occur anywhere).
- ♦ **Painful area that spreads quickly.**
- ♦ **Fever & chills** (if infection spreads).
- ♦ **Skin may blister or develop pus.**
- ♦ **Lymphangitis** (red streaks spreading toward the heart = **EMERGENCY** 🚨).

6. CELLULITIS TREATMENT

✓ **Oral Antibiotics (Mild Cases):**

- **Cephalexin (Keflex) or Dicloxacillin** – First-line treatment.
- **Clindamycin or Doxycycline** – If MRSA (Methicillin-Resistant Staph) is suspected.

✓ **IV Antibiotics (Severe Cases or Spreading Infection):**

- **Vancomycin (for MRSA), Ceftriaxone (for severe Strep infections).**
- ✓ **Elevate the Affected Area** – Reduces swelling.
- ✓ **Pain Control** – Acetaminophen (Tylenol) or Ibuprofen (Advil).

🚨 **When to Go to the ER:**

! If **red streaks appear** (sign of lymphangitis → infection is spreading to blood!).

! If **high fever, confusion, or dizziness** (signs of sepsis → life-threatening infection!).

! If **area of redness is rapidly growing** despite antibiotics.

7. NCLEX PRIORITIES FOR DERMATITIS & CELLULITIS

FOR DERMATITIS:

- ✓ Avoid Scratching (Prevents Infection).
- ✓ Apply Moisturizer (Prevents Dry, Cracked Skin).
- ✓ Use Antihistamines (For Severe Itching).
- ✓ Educate About Trigger Avoidance (Allergens, Irritants, Harsh Soaps).

FOR CELLULITIS:

- ✓ Monitor for Red Streaks or Worsening Symptoms (Signs of Spreading Infection).
- ✓ Keep Area Elevated (Reduces Swelling & Pain).
- ✓ Encourage Full Course of Antibiotics (Prevents Recurrence).
- ✓ Monitor for Signs of Sepsis (Low Blood Pressure, Fever, Confusion).

8. NCLEX "MUST-KNOW" CONCEPTS

- ♦ Dermatitis = Inflammation (NOT an infection) → No antibiotics needed!
- ♦ Cellulitis = Bacterial infection → Needs antibiotics!
- ♦ Red Streaks on Skin = EMERGENCY (Lymphangitis → Call Doctor Immediately!).
- ♦ Seborrheic Dermatitis ("Dandruff") = Treat with Antifungal Shampoo!
- ♦ Compression Stockings Help with Stasis Dermatitis (Poor Leg Circulation)!